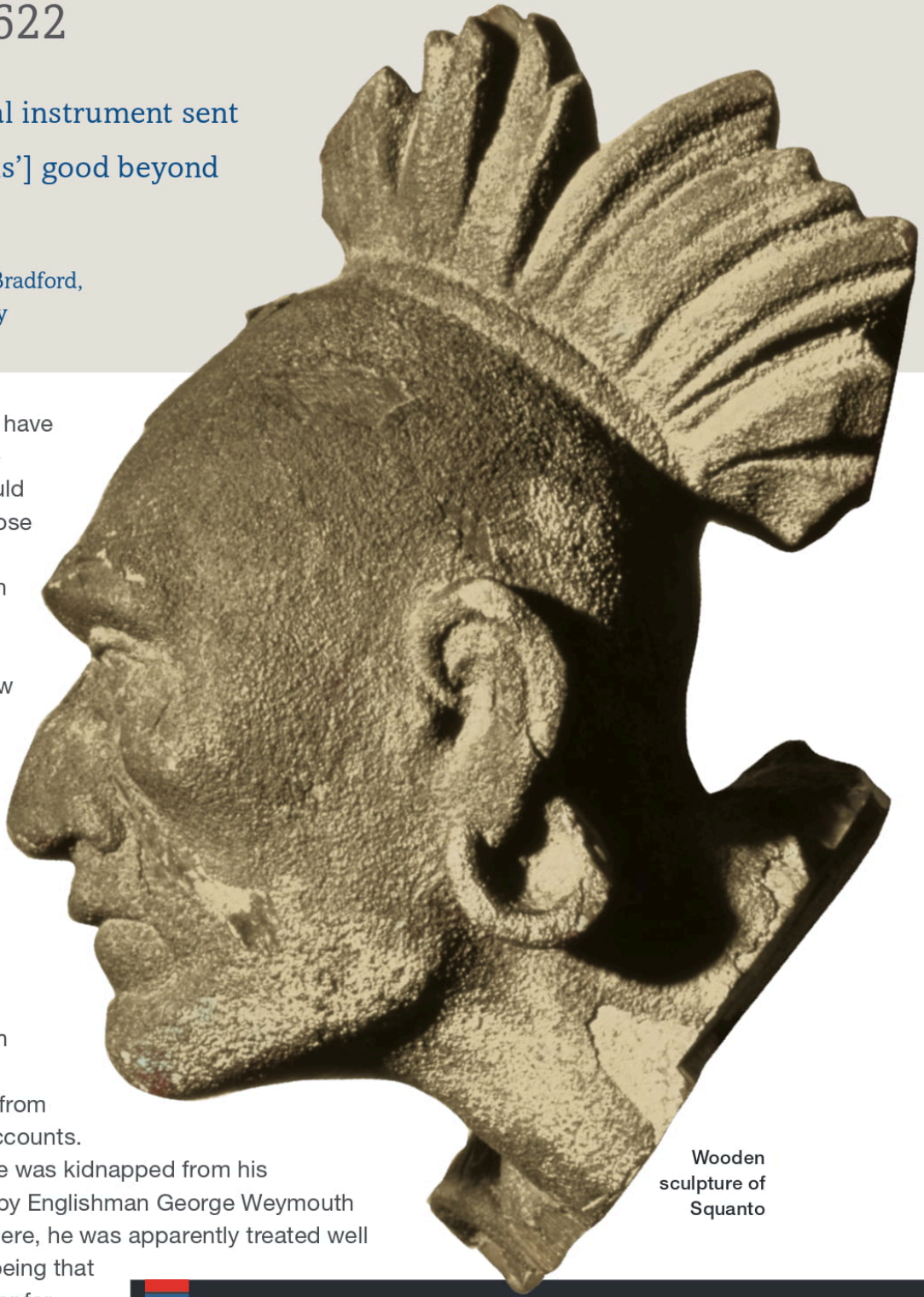
AMERICAN VOICES

2.2 Squanto

c. 1580–1622

"[Squanto] was a special instrument sent of God for [the Pilgrims'] good beyond their expectation."

—from the journal of William Bradford, governor of Plymouth Colony



Wooden sculpture of Squanto

The Pilgrims certainly couldn't have expected that a fluent English-speaking Native American would happen on the scene and choose to act as their interpreter and guide. So Squanto, also known as Tisquantum, must have seemed like a gift indeed. He taught the Pilgrims how to grow maize and where to catch fish, and generally showed them the ropes so they could survive in Plymouth. Squanto even died in the Pilgrims' service. What we don't know for sure is exactly what came before.

EARLY LIFE

Part folk hero, part myth, much of what we know—or think we know—about Squanto comes from often conflicting eyewitness accounts. According to some sources, he was kidnapped from his Massachusetts home in 1605 by Englishman George Weymouth and taken to England. While there, he was apparently treated well and taught English—the idea being that he would serve as an interpreter for those settling the colonies. John Smith, one of the founders of Jamestown Colony, is said to have returned him to America for that purpose around 1615.

Remarkably, Squanto was kidnapped a second time, an event on which most authorities agree. One of Smith's men,

Pilgrim Hall Museum
Plymouth, Massachusetts

The nation's oldest continuously operating public museum, Pilgrim Hall, tells the founding story of America: the Pilgrims' arrival, struggles, and first Thanksgiving in Plymouth. This 19th-century sculpture of Squanto forms part of the museum's collection. It shows what one artist thinks the Native American guide might have looked like.

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Thomas Hunt, took Squanto and several other Native Americans to Spain where the Englishman hoped to sell them into slavery. Fortunately, Squanto managed to get away. Some say Spanish priests rescued him. Most accounts, though, have him escaping to England and befriending merchants in London. This period, then, may have been when Squanto learned English. In 1619, he sailed with the merchants to New England to help them establish trade with the Native Americans.

LIFE AMONG THE PILGRIMS

Squanto returned to his homeland only to find that most of his people—the Pawtuxet—had been wiped out by disease. For a time, he lived with the Wampanoag (WAHMP-uh-noh-ag). Then, in early 1621, a Native American named Samoset brought Squanto to Plymouth Colony. Samoset had been the first Native American to greet the Pilgrims. But, with his limited understanding of English, he couldn't really speak to them. Squanto, he knew, had a far better command of the language.

Guide—and Troublemaker?

Squanto was known for his role as the Pilgrims' guide. But stories have also circulated about trouble he caused. For example, fearful of losing his position of power, Squanto tried to pit the Pilgrims against the Native Americans. He spread rumors that Massasoit was joining forces with other tribes in a plan to attack the Pilgrims.

When Squanto's plot was uncovered, Massasoit demanded that Squanto be turned over for punishment. Certain that the Wampanoag chief would execute Squanto, William Bradford refused. With more colonial ships arriving in the area, Bradford knew that he and the new settlers would need Squanto more than ever.

Before long, Squanto became an indispensable member of the colony. He taught the settlers how to plant local crops and served as their ambassador on trading expeditions. He even helped negotiate a peace treaty between the Pilgrims and the Wampanoag chief, Massasoit. In the fall of 1621, the Wampanoag, the Pilgrims, and Squanto celebrated the peace and Plymouth's successful harvest with the first Thanksgiving.

Squanto's time in Plymouth turned out to be brief. While guiding William Bradford on an expedition around Cape Cod, the Native American contracted a fever and died. According to some sources, Squanto said to Bradford on his deathbed, "Pray for me, Governor, that I might go to the Englishmen's God in heaven." Apparently, the Pilgrims had had a powerful influence on Squanto. He could have no idea that his own influence and aid had helped secure the survival of the colonists.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did Squanto help the Pilgrims in Plymouth?
2. **FORM AND SUPPORT OPINIONS** Do you think the treaty with the Wampanoag could have been created without Squanto? Why or why not?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** Based on his dying words, what did Squanto learn from the Pilgrims?

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